IMPACT WEEKLY

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A Sunday synthesis of India's CSR week - context, connections and what the week's moves mean.

THE WEEK IN CONTEXT

The bell rang; the ministry has not counted what it rings in

Lighthouse Communities Foundation completed the exchange route this paper tracked all month, the Centre confirmed it has no assessment of what that route brings in, and the week's firmest outcome numbers came from five- and thirteen-year retrospectives.

Eighteen days after this review first tracked Lighthouse Communities Foundation's public issue, the livelihoods non-profit rang the bell at the BSE's Social Stock Exchange on 29 October - the first zero-coupon zero-principal listing this paper has followed end to end. Issue funds expand its Pune programme for 500 young people. The listing also completes a policy loop: since the 27 May notification added ZCZP subscriptions to Schedule VII as item (xiii), companies can count them toward CSR, capped at 10% of a year's CSR spend. NSDC's NABARD-subscribed issue listed the previous week; the exchange route is now open at both bourses.

What the route delivers is, by the government's own account, unmeasured. Asked in the Lok Sabha whether the 27 May change is likely to boost institutional capital into the social sector, the Ministry of Corporate Affairs said no such assessment has been conducted; the stated aim is ease of compliance and a transparent, regulated channel for non-profits. The demand evidence is thin - last week a twice-extended ₹1-crore issue from Grace Cancer Foundation closed at a reported 0.07 times subscribed. What the bell changes is accountability: Lighthouse now reports through the exchange's disclosure framework.

The week's outcome numbers came from looking backwards. Tata Capital's CSR initiatives have benefited 5.5 lakh people in Maharashtra over five years - about 30% of its total CSR expenditure was incurred in the state, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis said, with over 37 lakh reached nationwide. Apollo's Total Health model marked 13 years at Aragonda with 10.89 lakh meals served, by the company's count. Both ledgers are attributed - one to a chief minister's statement, one to a company release - and both are the kind of counting the exchange route will now have to produce.

WHAT CHANGED - AND WHY IT MATTERS

1. Lighthouse lists on the BSE SSE - the arc, completed

The livelihoods non-profit marked its Zero Coupon Zero Principal listing on 29 October with a bell-ringing at the bourse. Issue funds expand the Pune programme - 500 young people into career awareness, confidence and job-readiness. The programme runs 51 centres across six states; women make up nearly 60% of enrolments, and 77% of placed youth are still in employment a year later.

Why it matters: the first ZCZP this paper tracked from subscription to listing; every future claim now runs through exchange disclosure.

Fortune India, 29 Oct

2. The Centre has no assessment of what the ZCZP CSR route brings in

Answering Lok Sabha USQ 3559, the Ministry of Corporate Affairs confirmed the 27 May 2026 notification adding 'Subscription to zero coupon zero principal instruments on Social Stock Exchange' as Schedule VII item (xiii), capped at 10% of a company's total CSR expenditure for that financial year - and said it has conducted no assessment of how far the change boosts institutional capital into the social sector.

Why it matters: the route is being marketed to companies and non-profits alike, but the ministry's own baseline does not exist. Listing outcomes are the only data being produced.

Lok Sabha USQ 3559, answered 10 Aug

3. Maruti Suzuki gives its CSR a corporate form: the OSCOE Foundation

The board on 27 October approved a wholly owned Section 8 not-for-profit - Osamu Suzuki Centre of Excellence (OSCOE) Foundation, subject to Registrar of Companies approval - to promote vocational and technical skills for manufacturing excellence, including Japanese manufacturing philosophies and the teachings of Osamu Suzuki. The Regulation 30 filing states the activities will form part of CSR under Section 135 read with Schedule VII; initial paid-up capital is ₹1 lakh.

Why it matters: India's largest carmaker is building its skills CSR as a standing institution with its own board and filings, not an annual programme.

Maruti Suzuki NSE/BSE filing (via Kalkine India), 27 Oct

4. MCA extends FY26 filing deadlines - second year running

Financial statements may now be filed by 31 December 2026 and annual returns (MGT-7/7A) by 31 January 2027 without additional fees; the earlier deadlines were 31 October and 30 November. AGMs get no extension, and late filings attract fees counted from the original due dates. The circular covers consolidated statements, XBRL data and Ind AS statements for NBFCs; the report does not mention CSR filings.

Why it matters: compliance calendars across corporate India shift with this - and repeated extensions are becoming the pattern, not the exception.

Financial Express, 25 Oct

5. ₹22.5 crore of alumni giving builds India's first Physical AI school at IIT-Kharagpur

The Vinod Gupta family contributes ₹12.5 crore and an anonymous alumnus ₹10 crore toward the ₹35-crore Benjamin Gupta School of Physical AI, named for Gupta's late son, under an MoU with the IITKGP Foundation USA; the institute funds the rest. The school will work on physics-informed machine learning, digital twins, intelligent robotics and advanced sensing alongside the Department of Artificial Intelligence. An alumni-philanthropy initiative, not billed as CSR.

Why it matters: last week a lobby proposed routing CSR into research; this week philanthropy simply did it - the money reached frontier research faster outside Schedule VII than inside it.

Indian Express (PTI inputs), 27 Oct

6. Tata Capital's five-year ledger: 5.5 lakh people in Maharashtra, 37 lakh nationwide

Chief Minister Fadnavis said about 30% of the company's total CSR expenditure was incurred in Maharashtra: 6,400-plus Pankh scholarships, financial literacy for over 85,000 government-school students, ProAspire skilling for over 26,000, eye care for over two lakh under Aarogyatara, cancer initiatives benefiting over 30,000, and Jaladhar water security reaching 1.3 lakh people across 60-plus villages with over 600 water sources revived.

Why it matters: a retrospective counted in people, stated by a chief minister - the week's strongest measured-outcome story, and a template for what SSE disclosures will need.

PTI via Rediff, 30 Oct

EDITORIAL · OPINION

The bell rang; the count has not started

Lighthouse Communities Foundation completed the arc this review has followed: zero-coupon zero-principal instruments listed on the BSE Social Stock Exchange, money raised for a Pune livelihoods programme, disclosure now required through the exchange. The route the ministry opened in May is no longer theoretical.

What the route delivers remains, by the ministry's own account, unmeasured. Asked whether the Schedule VII change is likely to bring more institutional capital into the social sector, the Ministry of Corporate Affairs said no such assessment has been conducted. The stated purpose is ease of compliance and a regulated channel. The demand evidence so far is thin. Listing changes the reporting obligation; it does not yet change the evidence base.

The week's firmer numbers came from looking backwards. A chief minister counted 5.5 lakh people reached by one company's CSR in Maharashtra over five years. A hospital group marked thirteen years with a company-reported total of meals served. Both are attributed. Both are the kind of ledger the exchange route will now have to produce in public.

Elsewhere the form of CSR itself shifted. India's largest carmaker approved a Section 8 foundation to house its skills work — a standing institution with its own board and filings rather than an annual programme. Alumni philanthropy, outside Schedule VII, put money into a frontier research school shortly after a lobby had proposed routing CSR into research.

The instruments are multiplying. The measurement is not. Last week the discipline was that offers are not outcomes. This week the exchange rang the bell and the ministry confirmed it has not counted what the bell brings in. The organisations that will look clearest a year from now are the ones publishing the baseline, the method and the number — through the exchange or outside it.

DR. HEMANT L. PATEL

INSIDE THIS REVIEW

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- The Centre's answer: no assessment of the ZCZP CSR route
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- Quote of the week: a million youth

5.5 lakh

PEOPLE BENEFITED BY TATA CAPITAL'S CSR INITIATIVES IN MAHARASHTRA OVER FIVE YEARS

MAHARASHTRA CM'S STATEMENT; 37 LAKH REACHED NATIONWIDE - PTI, 30 OCT

NEXT REVIEW: SUNDAY, 8 NOVEMBER 2026

QUOTE OF THE WEEK

"We look forward to transforming a million youth, nationally - helping them choose and build the careers they aspire to."

DR. GANESH NATARAJAN, CO-FOUNDER & CHAIRMAN, LCF, AT THE BSE SSE LISTING, 29 OCT

THE LANDSCAPE: WHERE THE WEEK'S MONEY WENT

Livelihoods dominated the week, and increasingly arrived with a retention number. Lighthouse's listing put its 77% one-year employment retention on a regulated platform; IndiGoReach and Pratham opened a third skill centre at Shadnagar; Sandvik Coromant's Tech Sakhi will guide 1,500 schoolgirls toward manufacturing; CII Mysuru's She Leads reached 10,162 women students across 19 colleges; and Malabar's scholarships, inaugurated by the commerce minister, reached 33,000 girls this year. In the Sundarbans, a school pairing mothers' skill training with meals reported retention near 74% - attributed to the implementing society's director, without baseline data.

Health ran on retrospectives and equipment. Apollo's Total Health counted 13 years and 10.89 lakh meals; Tata Capital's Aarogyatara counted over two lakh eye-care patients; NALCO launched child anaemia screening across three Odisha districts; WCL began a Moringa nutrition programme for 2,000 children in Chhindwara; and a Lions Club grant - philanthropic, not CSR - gave Wadia children's hospital ₹1.16 crore of neurosurgical equipment.

States spent the week pulling CSR money toward their own priorities. Tamil Nadu said CSR from companies operating in the state should be spent in-state on college sports, eyeing the 2036 Olympics; Bihar's Chief Secretary urged companies toward government schools and nutrition through the State CSR Society; an Odisha MLA demanded a master plan to monitor CSR spending. Meanwhile DS Group and TERI moved Barota toward net-zero village status, MCL sanctioned ₹3.20 crore for an Anugul community hall, and RSPL published a decade of cumulative, company-reported work across coastal Gujarat.

THE MECHANISMS, EXPLAINED

What 27 May actually changed

One notification, one new Schedule VII item: (xiii), subscription to zero coupon zero principal instruments on a Social Stock Exchange. A CSR-mandated company may not put more than 10% of that year's total CSR expenditure into ZCZP subscriptions. The instruments pay no interest and return no principal - the subscription is the grant. The ministry's stated aims are ease of compliance and a transparent, regulated funding channel; asked what the change would do to institutional capital inflow, it said no assessment has been conducted.

Lok Sabha USQ 3559; notification of 27 May 2026

Section 8 as the CSR vehicle

A Section 8 company is a not-for-profit with a corporate skeleton - board, shareholders, statutory filings - and no dividends: surplus must serve the stated objects. Section 8 status alone is not enough to spend a company's CSR money. Rule 4 of the CSR Rules sets who may implement CSR: eligible entities must also register with the MCA through e-form CSR-1, and company-established or outside entities additionally need the prescribed income-tax registrations - for outside entities, a three-year track record as well. Maruti's OSCOE Foundation is the week's example of the form: the filing ties its skills mission to Section 135 read with Schedule VII but does not establish implementing-agency eligibility or CSR-1 status.

Companies (CSR Policy) Rules, 2014, rule 4 (as amended 2022); Maruti Suzuki filing, 27 Oct

What a listing commits the non-profit to

A ZCZP issue is not done when the bell rings. Listed non-profits report progress through the exchange's disclosure framework - how funds are used, and against which stated outcomes. Lighthouse's Pune expansion - 500 young people, from career awareness to job-readiness - now carries that obligation. The programme's existing ledger, 77% of placed youth still employed a year later, is the standard its disclosures will be held to.

Fortune India, 29 Oct

BY THE NUMBERS

77%
PLACED LIGHTHOUSE YOUTH STILL IN EMPLOYMENT A YEAR LATER

5.5 lakh
PEOPLE BENEFITED BY TATA CAPITAL'S CSR IN MAHARASHTRA OVER FIVE YEARS - CM'S STATEMENT

10.89 lakh
MEALS SERVED BY APOLLO'S TOTAL HEALTH OVER 13 YEARS - COMPANY-REPORTED

10%
CAP ON ZCZP SUBSCRIPTIONS AS SHARE OF A COMPANY'S YEARLY CSR SPEND

₹22.5 cr
ALUMNI GIVING BEHIND IIT-KHARAGPUR'S PHYSICAL AI SCHOOL

31 Dec
MCA'S EXTENDED FY26 FINANCIAL-STATEMENT FILING DEADLINE

THE WEEK AHEAD

FILING WATCH

FY26 financial statements now due 31 December; annual returns 31 January. AGMs unchanged, and late fees run from the original dates.

DISCLOSURE WATCH

Lighthouse's Pune expansion - 500 young people - now reports through the BSE SSE framework; the first disclosures are the test of the route.

ROC APPROVAL

Maruti's OSCOE Foundation awaits Registrar of Companies approval; the filing commits only ₹1 lakh of initial capital so far.

IN BRIEF

Apollo Foundation: Total Health marks 13 years at Aragonda - 10.89 lakh meals, 23-plus locations, 300-plus women employed; company-reported.

Federal Bank: ₹3-crore CSR grant agreed for Kochi's central kitchen, expanding the Samridhi@Kochi collective.

Sumangala Steel: ₹2.8 crore for 70 engineering scholarships, fourth edition; The Hindu's report does not bill it as CSR.

SBI Foundation & IIT Kanpur SIIC: ₹2.64-crore CSR support to 30 startups under SBIF LEAP.

IndiGoReach & Pratham: third skill centre opened at Shadnagar; over 5,000 youth targeted across three years.

Bihar: Chief Secretary urges PSUs, banks and companies to route CSR to government schools and children's nutrition via the State CSR Society.

Trident: Parali Samadhan targets nearly 2,000 acres this season, 202 completed in the current phase - company announcement, billed as CSR.

Impact Weekly is the Sunday knowledge review for Dr. Hemant L. Patel. Public reporting checked 1 Nov 2026, morning IST; the news is of 26-31 Oct. Commitments, targets and company-reported figures are recorded as such; they are not audited outcomes. causewave.in